

Commercial Burglary

Cloud evidence examination and timeline analysis

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Sanitized case study. Adapted from my original investigative report. Case identities, dates, locations and distinctive details are omitted. This is a newly written summary, not an original agency document.

The investigative question

In a commercial-burglary investigation, I examined cloud-account records obtained through legal process to identify relevant activity, establish its sequence and compare it with other investigative evidence.

My role and examination

I requested preservation of the account before obtaining provider records through a search warrant. I forensically imaged the returned records and processed them in AccessData Forensic Toolkit (FTK). I reviewed the provider authenticity documentation and compared provider-supplied hash values with the imaged files.

I compared the preserved records with a later account export, reviewed image metadata and organized relevant account activity chronologically. I bookmarked responsive artifacts and compared selected findings with independently obtained records.

Finding 1: Differences between data returns

What I found. Relevant images were present in the preserved records but absent from the later account export.

Why it mattered. The comparison identified evidence that would not have appeared in a review limited to the later export. It demonstrated the practical value of early preservation and gave me a discrepancy to document in the examination report.

Limit. The difference alone did not establish who removed material or why it was absent.

Finding 2: Activity around the incident

What I found. Account records contained searches concerning the location under investigation before the incident, followed by searches for public records and investigative information afterward.

Why it mattered. Organizing those artifacts in sequence made the activity available for comparison with the broader investigation. Search activity alone did not establish the identity or intent of the person using the account.

Findings into a usable report

Connecting source records, documented observations and appropriately limited conclusions.

Finding 3: A claim tested against records

What I examined. A claimed employment period and independently obtained records relevant to that period.

What I found. The claimed period conflicted with those records. I documented the inconsistency and its supporting source.

Why it mattered. The comparison identified a specific claim that required further scrutiny. It did not, by itself, establish involvement in the burglary.

The work product

I documented relevant artifacts, the sequence of account activity and the comparisons with other records in an investigative report. Bookmarked evidence and supporting material accompanied the findings for investigative and prosecutorial review.

My contribution was the examination and explanation of digital evidence: identifying relevant material, comparing sources, documenting discrepancies and reporting findings in context. This summary does not claim a charging decision, conviction or other case outcome.

Examination at a glance

Evidence examined	Work performed
Preserved cloud records and later export	Compared returns and identified differences in available images.
Account activity and image metadata	Reviewed artifacts and reconstructed relevant activity in sequence.
Independent investigative records	Tested a claimed employment period against another source.
Responsive artifacts and supporting records	Bookmarked evidence and documented findings in a report.

Reading this sample

The findings describe documented case work. Explanations of significance and limits are newly written for this portfolio. Broad sequence is retained; exact timestamps and elapsed intervals are omitted. Original records would be necessary to independently verify the detailed chronology.